

Lesson 2 Hosting Comparison Checklist

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Use this worksheet after the lesson to compare hosting plans with clear categories, published limits, and unknowns.

For a realistic worked example, use [lesson-02-woocommerce-lms-case-study.pdf](#) after filling this comparison checklist. It shows how a WooCommerce + education/LMS stack changes the hosting recommendation.

For enterprise, VIP-style, mission-critical, high-revenue, or high-traffic projects, also use [lesson-02-enterprise-vip-case-study.pdf](#). That version adds architecture proof, launch readiness, observability, deployment, support, security, and incident planning.

1. Site Profile

Question	Answer
Site type	Brochure / blog / WooCommerce / membership / LMS / booking / directory / custom-heavy
Main workload	Cached public pages / dynamic checkout / logged-in users / search / writes / imports / API calls
Critical actions	Checkout, login, search, form submission, course progress, booking, admin work, imports
Expected traffic pattern	Low steady traffic / spikes / campaigns / paid ads / seasonal sales
Plugin or extension risks	Woo extensions, builders, multilingual, memberships, payments, shipping, search, CRM, analytics
Business risk if slow/down	Low / medium / high
For enterprise projects, add the platform-risk profile:	
Enterprise area	Answer
Revenue or reputation risk	
Planned traffic events	
Logged-in or checkout workflows	
Teams involved	Developers / editors / marketers /

agencies / security / compliance / executives

Launch date and risk window

SLA/support expectation

Compliance or data handling concerns

Incident owner and escalation path

For WooCommerce + LMS projects, add the concrete stack:

Stack area	Selected tool	Published requirement checked	Practical impact
Commerce			Checkout, orders, payments, webhooks
LMS / education			Logged-in lessons, quizzes, progress writes
Security			Scans, firewall, login protection
SEO			Admin analysis, schema, redirects
Cache / image optimization			Public cache, image processing, cache exclusions
Email			Order, enrollment, password, notification emails
Forms / CRM / analytics			API calls, cron jobs, database writes

2. Requirements Check

Requirement area

WordPress requirements

WooCommerce or major plugin requirements

PHP version

Database version

HTTPS / SSL

PHP memory limit

Optional PHP extensions or services

Cron, webhooks, API access, email

Practical rule: minimum compatibility means the software can run. It does not prove the plan is a smooth performance fit for the real workload.

3. Category And Isolation Check

Plan	Provider	Exact plan family	Management layer	Resource isolation model	Why this model is supported
Plan A			Managed / self-managed	Shared account / managed multi-site server / single-site dedicated / VPS / cloud / platform	
Plan B			Managed / self-managed	Shared account / managed multi-site server / single-site dedicated / VPS / cloud / platform	
Plan C			Managed / self-managed	Shared account / managed multi-site server / single-site dedicated / VPS / cloud / platform	

Direct alternatives should match on both axes: management layer and resource isolation model. A plan can be managed and still share one resource pool across many sites.

4. Published Limits

Start with the pricing page for plan name, price, included features, and public positioning. Then check the provider's deeper technical documentation for the actual limits. Look for hosting limits, plan parameters, resource limits, product docs, help-center articles, terms pages, and support docs linked near the pricing table.

Field	Plan A	Plan B	Plan C	Notes
Pricing page checked				Commercial summary source.
Spec source checked				Limits page, help article, docs page, support confirmation, or live plan screen.
Sites / installs				Is the resource pool shared across many sites?
Storage capacity				Include backup/staging impact if known.
Storage type				HDD, SSD, NVMe, shared storage, published storage speed or read-write limits if available.
Inodes / file limits				Important for media-heavy sites and many small files.
Traffic / visits / transfer				Record enforcement method if

CPU count	published. Core count alone is incomplete.
CPU model	Shared, dedicated, burstable, throttled, CPU class/generation if published.
RAM	Total RAM is not the same as PHP memory limit.
PHP memory limit	For WooCommerce, 256 MB is a floor; 512 MB is a smoother average start, not a ceiling.
PHP workers / same-time requests	Workers affect how many dynamic PHP requests can run at the same time. They are not automatic speed.
Database limits	Size, connections, query limits, separate DB resources if published.
Object cache	Redis/Memcached/platform object cache if available.
Page cache / CDN	Helps public cached traffic, not every

Backups	dynamic request. Frequency, retention, restore process, staging restore.
Staging	Needed before risky optimization or store changes.
Support scope	Does support help with performance diagnosis or only server uptime?
Upgrade path	Can the site grow without migration pain?

Use “not published” when a field is missing after checking the pricing page and the deeper technical sources.

5. Practical Fit Decision

Fit area	Green	Yellow	Red
Category match	Same category comparison, clear responsibility model	Category boundary is understood	Mixed categories treated as equal
Site workload match	Plan fits dynamic/cache profile	Might work, needs monitoring	Plan chosen only by price, brand, storage, or visits
Resource visibility	Key limits published or confirmed	Some limits unknown but acceptable for risk level	Critical dynamic-resource limits hidden
WooCommerce readiness	Memory, CPU, workers, database, object cache, staging considered	Minimum met but practical headroom uncertain	Only generic WordPress support is checked
Storage quality	Capacity, type, file count limits, backup pool, read-write behavior considered	Capacity/type known, deeper storage behavior unknown	Only GB number considered

CPU quality	Shared/dedicated/ burst/throttle model understood	Core count known, CPU model unclear	Core count treated as universal performance
Operations	Backups, staging, restore, support, monitoring clear	Some operations need manual setup	No clear restore path or support scope

6. Enterprise / VIP-Style Review

Use this section for mission-critical projects.

Layer	Required evidence
CDN / page cache	Cache hit rate target, cache bypass rules, purge plan, cookie/query-string behavior
Object cache	Hit rate, expensive operations cached, large object risk, metrics review
Database	Slow-query review, index plan, read/write pattern, table growth
Search	Native search, external search, indexing load, query cost
Media	External media/storage plan, image generation, migration volume, backup impact
Email	Transactional email provider, rate limits, bounce/failure handling
Background jobs	Cron/queue behavior, imports, webhooks, scheduled publishing, failed jobs
Third-party APIs	Payment, CRM, LMS, identity, analytics, retry behavior, timeout handling
Deployment	Git workflow, staging, production deploy, cache behavior, rollback, smoke tests
Observability	Logs, metrics, alerts, slow requests, real user metrics, Query Monitor/New Relic or equivalent
Security/access	Roles, least privilege, 2FA/SSO when available, secrets, WAF/security layer, vulnerability response
Launch readiness	DNS/TLS, content migration, access, testing, stakeholder sign-off
Support/escalation	Support tier, account owner, technical owner, incident communication

7. Final Recommendation Format

Use this structure when explaining your choice:

1. This site is a [site type], so the main workload risk is [dynamic/cache/database/API/etc.].
2. These plans match / differ by category because [category reason].
3. The strongest fit is [plan] because [published facts].
4. The main unknowns are [not published limits].
5. I would accept this plan only if [condition], and I would monitor [memory/CPU/workers/database/checkout/search/etc.].
6. If the site grows or hits limits, the next upgrade path is [upgrade/migration option].